xiào lǐ cáng dāo

笑里藏刀

A knife hidden in a smile.

Over 2,300 years ago, the king of Wei sent a beautiful woman to the king of Chu, as a gift. His wife, Zheng Xiu, took care of the new woman better than the king did: she picked the clothes and the rooms the new woman liked, and gave her the best of everything. Then, with one kind sentence, the new woman lost her nose and her place. This week you'll learn to write four characters: 笑, 里, 藏, 刀.

Stratagem No. 10 of 36 · one story, one lesson, four characters.

本周学：笑里藏刀 · 练字：笑、里、藏、刀

A GIFT FOR THE KING OF CHU



Behind a pillar, the wife watches the new woman come in.

According to the old book Zhan Guo Ce, this happened over two thousand three hundred years ago.

The king of Wei sent a beautiful woman to the king of Chu, as a gift. The king of Chu loved her.

His wife was named Zheng Xiu. She watched the new woman arrive.

She loved the new woman more than the king did. She picked the clothes and rooms the new woman liked.

She gave her the best of everything. The king saw this, and was moved. He said: jealousy is a woman's nature. His wife has none.

《战国策·楚策四》

A WARM FACE



A warm face, and one hand over the new woman's hand.

And his wife knew he thought that.

So she went to the new woman and said: the king loves your face. But he hates your nose.

And she said it with a warm face. When you see him, cover it.

The new woman believed her. She covered her nose every time. The king asked his wife: why does the new woman do that? She said: she seems to hate the smell of you.

The king said: how dare she. The order was carried out. She lost her nose, and her place. But the other old book adds one line: she had told the servants first.

《战国策·楚策四》《韩非子·内储说下》

WHY IT WORKED

Step	Who vs who	中文 · pinyin	Result
Smile	She gave her the best of everything	笑 xiào	It was the door
Warm face	One sentence got in	里 lǐ	A knife you cannot see
Step back	Her hand stayed empty	藏刀 cáng dāo	The hand belongs to someone else

刀不在她手里，刀在她的笑里。 笑里藏刀 xiào lǐ cáng dāo

THE ORIGINAL LINES

《三十六计·第十计 笑里藏刀》

The Thirty-Six Stratagems, No. 10 — "A knife hidden in a smile"

1

xìn ér ān zhī yīn yǐ tú zhī

信而安之，阴以图之，

Make him trust you and rest easy. Work in the dark.

2

bèi ér hòu dòng wù shǐ yǒu biàn

备而后动，勿使有变。

Move only when it is ready.

3

gāng zhōng róu wài yě

刚中柔外也。

Hard inside, soft outside.

Three lines, nothing more: twenty-one characters. The long commentary that follows in old editions is about a different man, in a later dynasty, and is not part of this text.

原文只有这三句，二十一个字。后面那段按语是老版本的注释，讲的是宋朝另一个人的事，不进原文框。

PRACTICE · 笑 XIÀO · 里 LǏ

Follow the numbers. Write each stroke in order.

先描一遍分解格，再在田字格里写 5 遍。

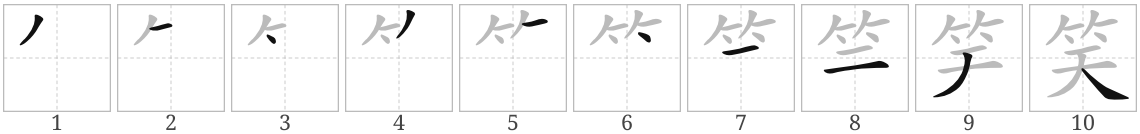
笑

xiào

to smile

10 strokes

STROKE ORDER



YOUR TURN

里

lǐ

inside

7 strokes

STROKE ORDER



YOUR TURN

PRACTICE · 藏 CÁNG · 刀 DĀO

Same order again. Write slowly, and say the sound out loud.

写完 4 个字，再回到第 7 页连写整句。

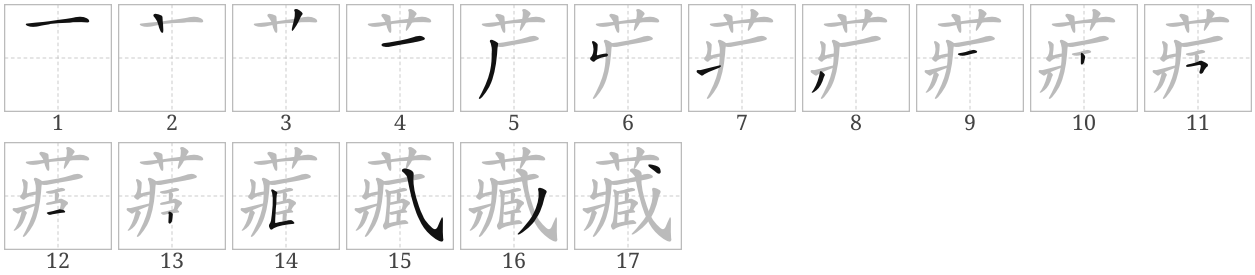
藏

cáng

to hide

17 strokes

STROKE ORDER



YOUR TURN

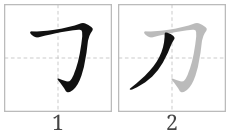
刀

dāo

knife

2 strokes

STROKE ORDER



YOUR TURN

PRACTICE · 笑里藏刀 XIÀO LǏ CÁNG DĀO

Trace the first row, then write the whole phrase four times. Say it out loud each time.

xiào	lǐ	cáng	dāo
笑	里	藏	刀

笑里藏刀 · A knife hidden in a smile.

THREE MORE WORDS

jiàn yì

1 建议

advice.

yǒu yì tiān tā gěi nǐ yì tiáo jiàn yì shuō de xiàng tí xǐng

有 一 天 她 给 你 一 条 建 议， 说 得 像 提 醒 。

One day she gives you advice, like a warning.

In this family, nobody corrects anyone at the table.

---

chén mò

2 沉默

silence.

tā bǎ zhè fèn chén mò dài dào ér zi miàn qián hái gěi tā qǐ le ge míng zi

她 把 这 份 沉 默 带 到 儿 子 面 前， 还 给 它 起 了 个 名 字 。

She takes that silence to her son, and names it.

She never lied.

---

tiáo kuǎn

3 条款

the terms; the clauses.

nǐ de tiáo kuǎn kě yǐ yìng nǐ de liǎn bú bì yìng

你 的 条 款 可 以 硬， 你 的 脸 不 必 硬 。

Your terms are hard. Your face does not have to be.

Nothing hidden. Nothing broken.

SPOT IT · STOP IT 识破 · 防住

She warned you while she was smiling. Later she took your silence to her son, and gave it a name. Every word she said to you was kind, and nothing she said was a lie.

外面软 · 里面有 *Warm outside, hard inside*	**外面软 · 里面空** *Warm outside, empty inside*
tiáo kuǎn zài zhǐ shàng 条 款 在 纸 上 *The terms are on paper*	zhǐ yǒu hǎo huà 只 有 好 话 *Only kind words*
rén hái zài duì miàn 人 还 在 对 面 *The person is still across the table*	zhǐ shì kōng de 纸 是 空 的 *The page is empty*
huà méi sī pò 话 没 撕 破 *Nobody has to shout*	qián shì bié rén de 钱 是 别 人 的 *The money is someone else's*

Two ways to use a smile. One is a manner. The other is a trap. Same face, different thing inside. So, one line: hard inside, soft outside.

一个笑，有两种用法：一种是修养，一种是陷阱。一样的脸，里面不一样。一句话：里面硬，外面软。

SEVEN DAYS, SEVEN QUESTIONS

Day 1 Which words did you believe, only because they were said kindly? 好话 hǎo huà

Day 2 Who gives you advice that sounds like a warning? 提醒 tí xǐng

Day 3 Which sentence of yours came back to you in someone else's words? 一句话 yí jù huà

Day 4 What did you stop saying at a table, and who noticed first? 沉默 chén mò

Day 5 Who is warm to your face — and where is their hand? 手 shǒu

Day 6 Which promise only holds while it costs nothing? 承诺 chéng nuò

Day 7 What would you check with one more person before you follow that advice? 对一次 duì yí cì

WEEK 10 REVIEW



The one-page summary of this week. 本周一图总结。

1. In one sentence: what did the wife actually do to the new woman?

2. What does 笑里藏刀 mean, in your own words?

3. Which of this week's four characters can you write now without looking: 笑, 里, 藏, or 刀?

4. Think of someone warm to your face. Where was their hand the last time it mattered?

Watch the hand, not the face — whose hand is it this week?
看手，不看脸：这一周，那是谁的手?
Kàn shǒu bú kàn liǎn: zhè yì zhōu nà shì shéi de shǒu?

BÓYÌ 博弈 · Think Like a Chinese Strategist · Week 10 · © 2026
For personal use only. Please don't share or resell.
Stroke data: Make Me a Hanzi (https://github.com/skishore/makemeahanzi), derived from Arphic Technology fonts under the Arphic Public License, via Hanzi Writer data.